

Artist Release Playbook

The Artist Release Playbook

How to Release Your Music Without It Getting Lost

Let's start with a hard truth:

Most songs don't fail because they're bad.

They fail because **no one knew they existed**.

Releasing music today isn't just about finishing a track and putting it out.

It's about building a **system around your song** before, during, and after release.

Think of this blog as your **playbook**.

Not theory. Not fluff. Something you can actually follow.

1. Before the Release: Is Your Song Actually Ready?

Before you think about Spotify, reels, or cover art, ask yourself one thing:

Does this song work without production?

There's a simple rule a lot of professionals follow:

The 80/20 Reality

- 80% of a song's impact comes from **writing + arrangement**
- 20% comes from **production + mixing**

If your track doesn't feel strong on:

- a simple guitar
- a basic piano
- or just your voice

...it won't magically become great later.

Try this:

Record a rough version on your phone.

If it still gives you *something*, emotion, groove, honesty, then you're onto something.

Use Reference Tracks (Without Copying Them)

This is one of the most underrated habits.

Pick 1–2 songs you love that are similar in vibe. Import them into your DAW and compare:

- How loud is the vocal?
- How heavy is the bass?
- How full does the track feel?

This isn't about copying. It's about **calibration**.

Also, your ears get tired. Fast.

Check your mix every 20–30 minutes against your reference to stay grounded.

Treat Your Vocal Like the Hero

This is an unsaid rule - The vocal carries the emotion.

Focus on:

- Clarity over loudness
- Emotion over perfection

Instead of just increasing volume, use:

- **Compression** to control dynamics
- **Automation** to shape phrases

If you want a pro-level touch:

Try **parallel compression**, it adds thickness without flattening your vocal.

2. The Pre-Release Phase: Where Most Artists Get Lazy

This is the boring part.

But this is also the part that separates serious artists from casual ones.

Start by creating a folder:

 **TRACK_NAME_FINAL_ASSETS**

This is your command center.

Your Must-Have Audio Files

At minimum, you should have:

- A **streaming-ready master** (~ -14 LUFS, with safe headroom)
- A **high-quality WAV** (24-bit / 44.1 kHz)
- A **short edit** (hook within 30–45 seconds)

That short version?

That's what works for reels, pitching, and attention spans.

Export Your Stems (Future You Will Thank You)

Break your track into:

- Vocals
- Drums
- Bass
- Instruments

Right now, it might feel unnecessary. It's not.

You'll need stems for:

- Live performances
 - Remixes
 - Sync opportunities (ads, films)
-

Test It in the Real World

Your studio lies. Real life doesn't.

Play your track on:

- Phone speakers
- Cheap earphones
- In a car (or even a rickshaw)

If it sounds muddy or weak anywhere, that's your mix telling you something.

3. Protect Your Work (Before It Blows Up)

This isn't exciting, but it's important.

Keep Proof of What You Used

If you've used samples (like from Splice or loop packs), keep the licenses.

Create a simple folder:

 Licenses & Rights

Be Careful with Sampling

Using uncleared film or Bollywood samples can get your song taken down, or worse.

Safer alternatives:

- Recreate the idea (interpolation)
 - Use royalty-free sounds
-

Decide Splits Early

If you're working with others, decide:

Who owns what %?

Write it down. Take a photo. Email it.

It sounds basic but it avoids serious problems later.

4. The Release Strategy (Timing > Talent Here)

Most artists rush this part.

Don't be like most artists!

Give Your Song 21 Days

Upload your track **at least 3 weeks in advance** through platforms like:

- DistroKid
- TuneCore
- Madverse

Why this matters:

- You can pitch to playlists
 - Platforms get time to process your release
 - You can plan your content properly
-

Set Up Your Artist Profile Properly

Before release, update:

- Your bio
- Your photos
- Your links

Because when someone clicks your name, this is what they see.

Think of it as your **homepage as an artist**.

5. The Content Engine (This Is What Drives Discovery)

Your song needs *context* to travel.

A Simple 4-Week Plan

Week 1-2: Build the vibe

Studio clips, visuals, snippets (don't reveal everything)

Week 3: Tell the story

Why did you make this song? What does it mean?

Week 4: Push the hook

10–15 second clips of the catchiest part

Make multiple versions

Not every video will work. That's normal.

Keep Visuals Simple

- Use a Spotify Canvas (8-second loop, vertical)
- Create basic visualizers

You don't need overproduction.

Consistency beats complexity every time.

6. Tools That Make Your Life Easier

You don't need expensive setups to start.

For Music

- [Audacity](#) (free and simple)
 - [Cakewalk](#) (full DAW, completely free)
-

For Content

- [Canva](#)
 - [CapCut](#)
-

For Growth

- [Spotify for Artists](#)
 - [Meta Ads Manager](#)
-

For Organization

- Google Drive
 - [Notion](#)
-

7. Don't Forget the Money Side

Register for Royalties

In India, sign up with:

- [Indian Performing Right Society](#)
- [Phonographic Performance Limited](#)

This is how you earn when your music is:

- Played publicly
 - Used commercially
 - Performed live
-

Build a Basic EPK

Have this ready:

- 2–3 good photos
- A short and long bio
- Links to your music

Keep it in one shareable folder.

8. After Release: This Is Where Momentum Is Built

Most artists disappear after release day.

You are not most artists!!

First 7 Days Matter Most

- Reply to comments
- Share audience reactions
- Keep posting

The algorithm is watching how people react early.

Turn One Song Into Many Pieces

From one track, create:

- Acoustic versions
- Behind-the-scenes clips
- Breakdowns

One song can easily become **15–20 pieces of content**

9. The Mindset That Actually Wins

Limit Who You Listen To

Take feedback from **2-3 trusted people only**.

Too many opinions = confusion.

Release More, Not Less

Don't over-perfect one song for months.

Because the truth is simple:

Your 10th release will be better than your first.

Final Thought

Talent gets attention.
But **systems build careers.**

If you follow a process like this consistently, you won't just drop songs, you'll build **momentum, identity, and growth** as an artist.

Start Here (Simple Action Plan)

- Finish your track and test it acoustically
- Create your **FINAL_ASSETS** folder
- Set a release date (minimum 3 weeks away)
- Plan your first 5 content pieces
- Export your stems today

This isn't just about releasing a song.

It's about learning how to stand behind your work, with clarity, with intention, and with a system that supports you.

Because the artists who last aren't the ones chasing perfect moments. They're the ones who build a rhythm of creating, releasing, learning, and evolving.

Every release teaches you something about your sound, your audience, and your voice.

And over time, that adds up to something far more powerful than a single track, It becomes **direction.**

So don't wait for everything to align.

Don't hold back your work trying to get it "just right."

Release. Observe. Refine. Repeat.

Because momentum isn't built in one drop, it's built in the courage to keep showing up.

And that's where real artists are made.

Breathing and Vocal Texture

Breathing Techniques for Singers

And How to Actually Improve Your Vocal Texture

Most singers think their problem is pitch.

It's not. It's breath.

Because breath is what controls:

- your **stability**
- your **power**
- your **tone (texture)**

If your breathing is off, your voice will feel:

- shaky
- strained
- thin
- inconsistent

And no amount of “sing louder” or “add emotion” fixes that.

Let's break this down properly.

1. First, What Does “Good Breathing” Even Mean?

A lot of people hear “breathe from your diaphragm” and... just get confused.

So let's simplify it.

 **Wrong idea:**

Breathing = chest going up and down

 **What actually works:**

Breathing = **expansion around your ribs and belly**

When you inhale correctly:

- your **shoulders don't lift**
- your **chest doesn't tense**
- your **lower ribs expand outward**

Think of it like this:

You're filling air **360 degrees around your torso**, not just up top.

2. The Foundation: Diaphragmatic Breathing

You don't need to control the diaphragm directly (you actually can't).
You need to create the *conditions* where it works naturally.

Exercise 1: The “Book on Belly” Drill

1. Lie down flat
2. Place a book on your stomach
3. Inhale slowly

The goal:

The book should rise, not your chest.

Do this for **5 minutes daily**

Why it works:

- Removes tension
 - Builds awareness of correct breathing
-

Exercise 2: 4–4–8 Control

- Inhale for 4 seconds
- Hold for 4
- Exhale slowly for 8

Once comfortable:

→ move to 4–4–12

This builds **breath control**, which directly affects how long and steady you can sing.

3. Breath Support (This Changes Everything)

Breathing in is only half the game.

What matters more is:

How you release the air while singing

The Real Goal:

Don't dump all your air at once.

Control it.

Exercise 3: The “Ssss” Drill

- Take a deep breath
- Release it on a “**ssssss**” sound
- Keep it steady for as long as possible

No breaks. No shaking.

This teaches:

- steady airflow
 - control under pressure
-

Exercise 4: Lip Trills (Underrated but Powerful)

Make a **brrrrr** sound (like a motor)

Now:

- slide up and down in pitch
- keep it smooth

If your trill stops = your airflow is inconsistent

This directly improves:

- vocal stability
- smooth transitions

- breath coordination
-

4. So Where Does “Vocal Texture” Come In?

Texture is what makes a voice feel:

- rich
- warm
- airy
- powerful
- emotional

And here’s the truth:

Texture is not something you “add”

It’s something that **emerges when your technique is right**

5. How to Improve Your Vocal Texture (Practically)

1. Fix Your Airflow First

If your breath is unstable:

- your tone will be shaky
- your voice will sound thin

Better breath = fuller sound.

Always.

2. Stop Oversinging

A lot of singers push too hard.

Result:

- strain
- harsh tone
- loss of texture

Instead:

Sing at **70% effort**

Let the mic do the work.

3. Play With Air vs Compression

Your texture sits between two extremes:

- **Too airy** → weak, breathy
- **Too tight** → strained, sharp

The sweet spot:

Balanced airflow + gentle compression

Exercise 5: Air vs Tone Control

Sing the same line in 3 ways:

1. Very breathy
2. Very tight
3. Balanced

Notice the difference.

That awareness = control.

4. Use Vowel Shaping

Small changes in vowels change tone massively.

Example:

- “Ah” → open, powerful
- “Ee” → bright, sharp

Practice singing the same phrase with different vowels

This helps you:

- colour your voice

- shape your texture intentionally
-

5. Record Yourself (Non-Negotiable)

What you hear while singing $\neq$ what others hear.

Use tools like:

- Audacity
- BandLab

Listen back and ask:

- Does it sound strained?
- Is it too airy?
- Is it consistent?

That's how improvement actually happens.

6. A Simple Daily Routine (15–20 Minutes)

If you're confused about where to start, do this:

5 mins – Belly breathing (book exercise)

5 mins – Ssss + lip trills

5 mins – Simple scales (focus on smooth airflow)

5 mins – Sing a song (apply control, don't push)

Consistency > intensity

7. Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Raising your shoulders while breathing
- Singing too loudly too soon
- Ignoring breath control
- Chasing "style" before fixing basics
- Not recording yourself

Final Thought

A great voice isn't built by singing harder.

It's built by singing **smarter**.

When your breath is steady,
your voice stops fighting you.

And that's when texture shows up, naturally, effortlessly, honestly.

Start Here (Today)

- Practice the **4-4-8 breathing** for 5 minutes
- Do **lip trills for 3 minutes**
- Record yourself singing one verse
- Listen back (objectively)

Do this for 7 days.

You won't just hear a difference. You'll *feel* it.

How to Riyaaz

The Daily Riyaaz Routine

A Practical Guide to Improving Your Voice (Even If You Only Have 20 Minutes)

Most singers don't lack talent.

They lack **structure**.

One day you're doing alankars.

Next day you're just singing songs.

Then 3 days... nothing.

And slowly, you start feeling stuck.

Here's the truth:

It's not about how long you practice.

It's about *how consistently and correctly* you practice.

This blog gives you a **simple, repeatable riyaaz system**, something you can follow daily without overthinking.

1. First: What Is Riyaaz *Actually* Meant to Do?

Riyaaz isn't just "singing for practice."

It's training:

- your **breath**
- your **pitch**
- your **control**
- your **tone (texture)**

Think of it like going to the gym.

You don't just lift random weights.

You follow a **routine**.

2. The Biggest Mistake Singers Make

They only practice **songs**.

Songs are performance.

Riyaaz is training.

If you skip training, your voice never really improves.

3. The Ideal Daily Structure (20–30 Minutes)

You don't need 2 hours.

You need **consistency + structure**.

The 4-Part Riyaaz Framework

1. Breath & Warm-Up (5 mins)

2. Voice Opening (5 mins)

3. Control & Practice (10–15 mins)

4. Application (5–10 mins)

Let's break this down.

4. Step 1: Breath & Warm-Up (5 Minutes)

Start here. Always.

Because if your breath is unstable, everything else suffers.

What to Do:

- 4-4-8 breathing (inhale-hold-exhale)
 - Slow deep breaths (no shoulder movement)
-

Pro Tip (Most People Don't Do This):

Practice breathing **with a count AND with a metronome**

Use:

- Soundbrenner

This builds *rhythmic breath control*, which directly helps in singing phrases.

5. Step 2: Voice Opening (5 Minutes)

Now you gently wake up your voice.

Not force it.

What to Do:

- Lip trills (brrrr)
- Humming (closed mouth)
- Light “aa” or “oo” scales

Keep it soft. No pushing.

Pro Tip:

Start in your **comfortable range**, not your highest note.

Most strain happens in the first 5 minutes.

6. Step 3: Control & Core Practice (10-15 Minutes)

This is where actual improvement happens.

What to Practice:

Alankars (Pattern Work)

- Sa Re Sa
- Sa Re Ga Re Sa
- Simple ascending/descending patterns

Focus on:

- staying in pitch
 - smooth transitions
-

One Note Stability Drill (Underrated)

Hold a single note (like “Sa”) for as long as possible.

Goal:

- steady pitch
- no shaking

This builds insane control over time.

Pro Tip (Advanced but Powerful):

Practice **slow alankars**

Most people rush.

Slow practice:

- improves accuracy
 - builds muscle memory
 - reveals mistakes
-

Use a Tanpura (Non-Negotiable)

Use:

- iTanpura

- Tanpura Droid

This trains your ear to stay in sur naturally.

7. Step 4: Application (5-10 Minutes)

Now apply everything to music.

What to Do:

- Sing one song or bandish
- Focus on:
 - breath control
 - smoothness
 - expression

Not perfection. Awareness.

Pro Tip:

Sing the same line:

- once normally
- once softer
- once with more airflow

This helps you discover your vocal texture.

8. Weekly Upgrade System (How You Actually Improve)

Doing the same thing daily is good.

Improving it is better.

Every Week:

- Increase breath duration slightly
- Try a slightly higher/lower scale
- Add one new alankar

Small upgrades = big long-term growth

9. Tools That Make Riyaaaz Easier

Pitch & Practice

- Vocal Pitch Monitor (see your pitch in real-time)
 - Riyaz
-

Tanpura & Scale

- iTanpura
 - Tanpura Droid
-

Timing & Discipline

- Soundbrenner
-

Recording Yourself (Non-Negotiable)

- Audacity
- BandLab

If you're not recording, you're guessing.

10. Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Singing too loudly too soon

- Skipping warm-ups
- Practicing randomly
- Not using a tanpura
- Inconsistency

20 minutes daily > 2 hours once a week

11. What Most People Don't Tell You

This is important.

You won't "feel" improvement every day.

Some days:

- your voice will feel heavy
- your pitch will slip
- your range will shrink

That's normal.

Progress in singing is **non-linear**

The only thing that works is **showing up anyway**

Final Thought (TSC Tone)

Riyaaz isn't about chasing perfection.

It's about building a relationship with your voice.

Day by day, note by note, breath by breath you start understanding it.

Controlling it.

Trusting it.

And eventually, expressing through it.

Start Today (Simple Plan)

- 5 mins breathing
- 5 mins lip trills + humming
- 10 mins alankars
- 5 mins song

Set a timer. Don't overthink it.

Just begin.

Because the singers who grow aren't the ones who wait for the perfect routine, they're the ones who **show up, every single day.**

Wanna get into the depth of Riyaaz and Hindustani Classical Music? We have curated an immersive learning program for you with Pt. Prasad Khaparde, disciple of Ustad Rashid Khan from the Rampur Shaswan Gharana with 30+ years of experience.

Know more at: <https://tscacademy.in/course-hindustani-classical.html>